

Yin Organ Interrelationships

12

Key contents

Interrelationships between:

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Interrelationship is the essence of Chinese medicine since the body is regarded as an integrated whole. Because of this it is not enough to consider the Yin organs merely on an individual basis. To understand them properly we must consider how they interrelate, since a person's health depends on a proper balance being maintained among the internal organs.

The Interrelationships of the Yin organs will be discussed under the following headings:

- Heart and Lungs
- Heart and Liver
- Heart and Kidneys
 - The mutual assistance of Fire and Water
 - The common root of Mind (*Shen*) and Essence (*Jing*)
 - The interrelationship of Heart and Kidneys in the menstrual cycle
- Liver and Lungs
 - The relationship between Lung-Qi and Liver-Blood
 - The relationship between the descending of Lung-Qi and the ascending of Liver-Qi
- Liver and Spleen
- Liver and Kidneys

- Spleen and Lungs
- Spleen and Kidneys
- Lungs and Kidneys
 - The relationship between Lungs and Kidneys with regard to Qi
 - The relationship between Lungs and Kidneys with regard to fluids
- Spleen and Heart

HEART AND LUNGS

The Heart governs Blood and the Lungs govern Qi: the relationship between Heart and Lungs is thus essentially the relationship between Qi and Blood (Fig. 12.1). Qi and Blood are mutually dependent as Qi is the commander of Blood and Blood is the mother of Qi. As Qi is the commander of Blood, Qi makes Blood circulate and if Qi stagnates (or if it is deficient), Blood stagnates. Blood needs the power of Qi in order to circulate in the blood vessels and Qi can only circulate throughout the body by 'concentrating' in the blood vessels. That is why it is said in Chinese medicine that 'Qi controls warmth' (here 'warmth' means warm nourishment and motive power), and that 'Blood controls immersion' ('immersion' here means the fluids which provide the vehicle for this nourishment and motive power).¹

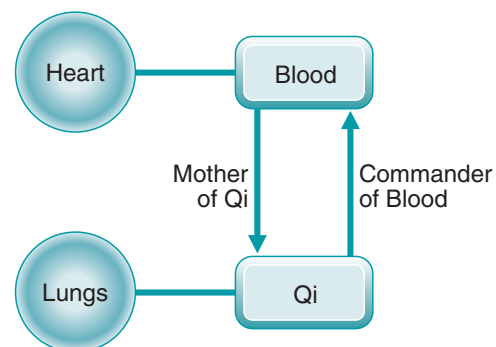


Figure 12.1 Relationship between Heart and Lungs



Blood needs the warmth of Qi to circulate, while Qi needs the 'immersion' (i.e. liquid quality) of Blood as a vehicle to circulate

On the other hand, as Blood is the mother of Qi, Blood nourishes Qi.

The relationship between Qi and Blood in this respect depends on the relationship between Lungs and Heart. Although it is the Heart that drives the Blood through the blood vessels, it relies on the Lungs to provide the Qi for this job. On the other hand, the Lungs rely on Blood from the Heart for nourishment.

Because of this, if Lung-Qi is deficient, it can lead to stagnation of Qi of the Heart, which, in turn, causes stagnation of Blood of the Heart. This manifests with palpitations, pain in the chest and blue lips. Excessive Heart-Fire dries up the Lung fluids, causing a dry cough, dry nose and thirst.

In practice it is common for both Heart- and Lung-Qi to be deficient at the same time as they are so closely related and they are both situated in the chest. Furthermore, Gathering Qi (*Zong Qi*), which collects in the chest, influences both Heart and Lung functions and the circulation of both Qi and Blood. If Gathering Qi is weak, the voice will be weak and the hands will be cold, as Qi and Blood of Lung and Heart will be diminished.



Clinical note

Ren-17 Shanzhong tonifies the Gathering Qi (*Zong Qi*) and both Lungs and Heart

Sadness often depletes both Lung- and Heart-Qi and is manifested with a pulse that is Weak in the Front position of both left and right side.



Clinical note

When sadness affects both Lungs and Heart and the pulse is weak on both Front positions, LU-7 Lieque and HE-7 Shenmen are indicated

Finally, the relationship between Lungs and Heart is seen also in the process leading to Blood. Food-Qi (*Gu Qi*) of the Spleen goes to the Heart to make Blood:

however, it ascends to the Heart, through the moving action of Lung-Qi.

Box 12.1 summarizes the interrelationship between the Heart and the Lungs.

Box 12.1 Heart and Lungs

- Heart governs Blood, Lungs govern Qi
- Qi is the commander of Blood, Blood is the mother of Qi
- If Qi circulates well, Blood circulates; if Qi is stagnant, Blood stagnates
- Qi provides warmth to Blood, Blood provides a liquid vehicle for Qi
- Gathering Qi of the chest is influenced by both Lungs and Heart
- Food Qi of the Spleen goes to the Heart to make Blood through the agency of the Lungs

HEART AND LIVER

The interrelationship between Heart and Liver hinges on their roles in respect of Blood. The Heart governs Blood while the Liver stores Blood and regulates its volume: these two activities must be coordinated and harmonized. It is very common for a deficiency of Liver-Blood to cause a deficiency of Heart-Blood as not enough Blood is stored by the Liver to nourish the Heart, causing palpitations and insomnia. In Five-Element terms this situation would be described as the 'Mother not nourishing the Child'.



Clinical note

Liver-Blood deficiency leading to Heart-Blood deficiency is a common cause of postnatal depression. Blood loss from the uterus during childbirth causes Liver-Blood deficiency, which, in turn, induces Heart-Blood deficiency. Deficient Heart-Blood fails to anchor and house the Mind (*Shen*): this causes depression, anxiety, insomnia and palpitations

On the other hand, if Heart-Blood is deficient, this may disrupt the Liver's ability to regulate the Blood and it gives rise to dizziness and excessive dreaming. In Five-Element terms this situation would be described as the 'Child draining the Mother'.

On a mental level, the Heart houses the Mind and influences the mood and spirits of a person, while the Liver is responsible for the smooth flow of Qi. The smooth flow of Qi of the Liver has a deep influence on the emotional state; on an emotional level, the smooth

flow of Liver-Qi ensures that the emotions experienced by the patients 'flow' smoothly, that they are not repressed, that they are expressed appropriately, and that they do not take over the person's life: in short, the smooth flow of Liver-Qi on an emotional level ensures that our emotions do not turn into moods to possess us (Fig. 12.2). The Mind (through the Heart) and our emotional state (through the Liver) are interdependent. The Mind controls the emotions in the sense that it recognizes and feels them: this has an influence on the recognition and expression of our emotions in an appropriate way. On the other hand, the Liver, through the smooth flow of its Qi ensures that the emotions flow smoothly and do not affect the Mind in a prolonged way.

A weak Heart and a low Mind may lead to depression and anxiety: this would influence the smooth flow of Liver-Qi and therefore the emotional state. On the other hand, stagnation of Liver-Qi impairs the smooth flow of Qi and constrains the emotions, which may

lead to a weakening of the Mind and a lowering of vitality (Fig. 12.3).

Finally, the Heart and Liver are closely linked on a psychological level through the connection between Mind (*Shen*) and Ethereal Soul (*Hun*) (see Fig. 12.3). As described in chapter 7, the Ethereal Soul represents the 'coming and going of the Mind' which means that it gives the Mind 'movement' in the sense of relationships with others, inspiration, vision, capacity for planning, a sense of direction in life, etc. On the other hand, the Mind controls, directs and integrates the psychic material coming from the Ethereal Soul so that this is integrated properly within our psyche (see Fig. 4.14).

Box 12.2 summarizes the interrelationship between the Heart and the Liver.

Box 12.2 Heart and Liver

- The Heart governs Blood, the Liver stores Blood
- Liver-Blood deficiency often leads to Heart-Blood deficiency
- The Heart houses the Mind, the Liver houses the Ethereal Soul
- The Heart (through the Mind) recognizes, controls and integrates emotions; the Liver ensures the smooth flow of emotions
- The Ethereal Soul (of the Liver) is the 'coming and going' of the Mind (of the Heart)

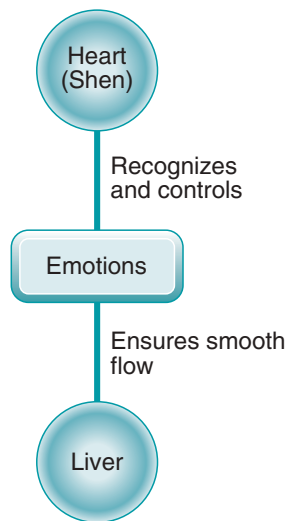


Figure 12.2 Relationship between Heart and Liver with regard to emotions

HEART AND KIDNEYS

The interrelationship of Heart and Kidneys is very important in clinical practice. This relationship has three aspects:

- The mutual assistance of Fire and Water
- The common root of Mind (*Shen*) and Essence (*Jing*)
- The interrelationship of Heart and Kidneys in the menstrual cycle

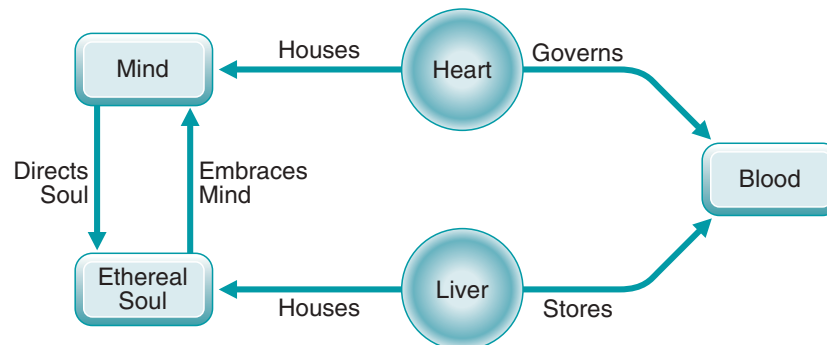


Figure 12.3 Relationship between Mind and Ethereal Soul and emotions

The mutual assistance of Fire and Water

Heart belongs to Fire and is in the Upper Burner: Fire is Yang in nature and corresponds to movement.

The Kidneys belong to Water and are in the Lower Burner: Water is Yin in nature and corresponds to stillness. Heart and Kidneys must be in balance as they represent two fundamental poles of Yang and Yin, Fire and Water. It should be stressed here that although from a Five-Element perspective Fire and Water control each other (i.e. Fire dries up Water and Water douses Fire), in this context, Fire and Water interact with each other and mutually nourish each other. The relationship between Fire and Water highlights the importance of a connection and link between these two Elements and therefore between Heart and Kidneys. In a way, this relationship is similar to that between Lungs and Kidneys: as described in [chapter 10](#), Lung-Qi descends to the Kidneys and the Kidneys respond by 'grabbing' and holding Qi down. Similarly, Heart-Qi descends to the Kidneys, which hold it; likewise, Kidney-Qi ascends to the Heart.



Fire and Water are interdependent and mutually assist each other. In physiology, Fire does not dry up Water and Water does not douse Fire

Heart-Yang descends to warm Kidney-Yin; Kidney-Yin ascends to nourish and cool Heart-Yang. The energy of the Heart and Kidneys is in constant interchange above and below. Chinese medicine refers to this as the 'mutual support of Fire and Water', or the 'mutual support of Heart and Kidneys'.



Clinical note

Ren-15 Jiuwei and Ren-4 Guanyuan promote the communication between Heart and Kidneys

If Kidney-Yang is deficient, the Kidneys cannot transform the fluids, which can overflow towards the top, causing the pattern called 'Water insulting the Heart'. If Kidney-Yin is deficient, it cannot rise to nourish Heart-Yin, which leads to the development of Empty-Heat of the Heart, causing palpitations, mental restlessness, insomnia, red flushed cheekbones, night

sweats, and a Red Peeled tongue with a crack in the centre. These two situations are characterized by a loss of contact between Heart and Kidneys.

The common root of Mind (*Shen*) and Essence (*Jing*)

The Heart houses the Mind; the Kidneys store Essence. Mind and Essence have a common root. Essence is the fundamental substance from which the Mind is derived. As we saw in [chapter 3](#), Essence, Qi and Mind represent three different states of condensation of Qi, the Essence being the densest, Qi being more rarefied, and the Mind being the most subtle and immaterial. According to Chinese medicine, Essence and Qi are the essential foundation of the Mind. If Essence and Qi are healthy and flourishing, the Mind will be happy and this will lead to a healthy and happy life. If Essence and Qi are both depleted, then the Mind necessarily will suffer.

Thus a healthy Mind depends on the strength of the Essence, which is stored in the Kidneys. The Pre-Heaven Essence is the foundation of the Mind, while the Post-Heaven Essence provides nourishment for the Mind. An ample supply of Essence is the precondition for a normal activity of the Mind and a vigorous Mind is the precondition for a productive Essence. The relationship between Essence and Mind highlights the Chinese view of the body and mind as an integrated whole, one influencing the other, with both body and mind having a common root in Qi.

If Essence is weak, the Mind will suffer and the person will lack vitality, self-confidence and will-power. If the Mind is perturbed by emotional problems, the Essence will not be directed by the Mind and the person will feel permanently tired and lack motivation ([Fig. 12.4](#)).

The relationship between the Mind and Essence reflects also that between the Mind and Will-power (*Zhi*), which is the spiritual aspect of the Kidneys. If the Kidney-Essence is weak, the Will-power will be diminished and this will affect the Mind negatively: the person will be depressed and lacking in vitality, will-power, drive and determination.

The interrelationship of Heart and Kidneys in the menstrual cycle²

The interrelationship between Heart and Kidneys is essential for a healthy menstrual cycle. The menstrual

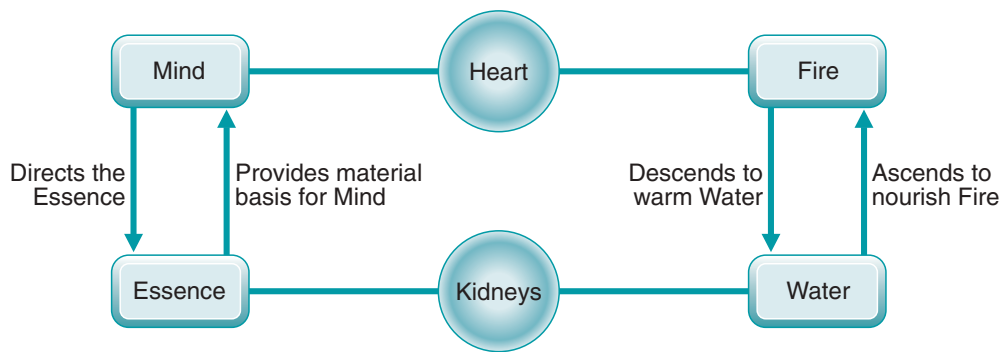


Figure 12.4 Relationship between Mind and Essence

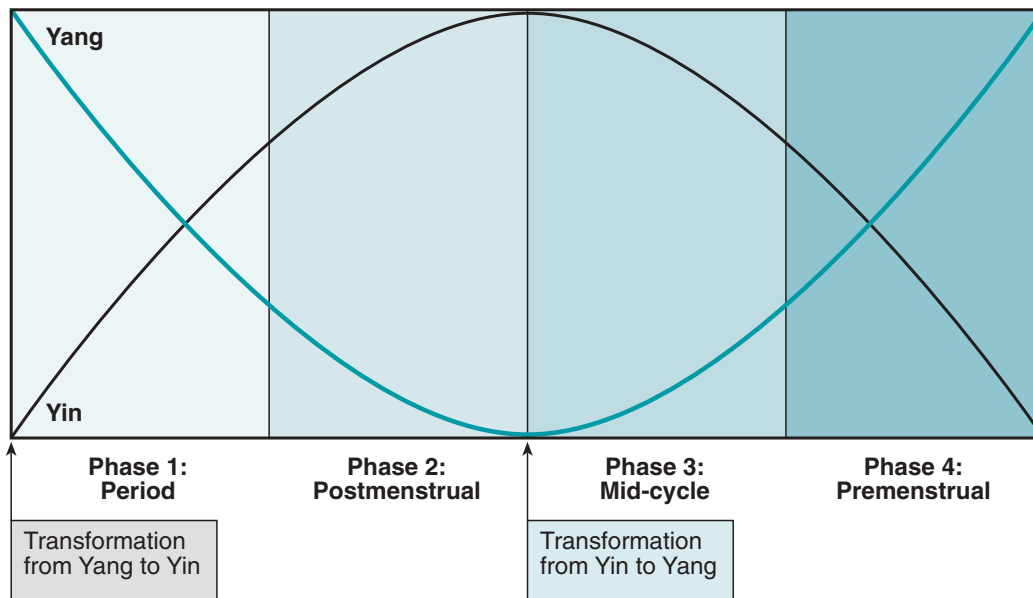


Figure 12.5 Relation between Heart and Kidneys with regard to menstrual cycle

cycle itself is a flow of Kidney-Yin and Kidney-Yang as the Kidneys are the origin of *Tian Gui*, which is the basis for menstrual blood. In the first half of the cycle Yin is growing, reaching a maximum at ovulation; with ovulation, Yin begins to decrease and Yang to increase, reaching a maximum just before the onset of the period. This ebb and flow of Yin and Yang is determined by Kidney-Yin and Kidney-Yang. Thus, the onset of the period marks a rapid change from Yang to Yin (i.e. Yang decreases rapidly), while ovulation marks a rapid change from Yin to Yang (i.e. Yin has reached its maximum). Therefore, the onset of the period and ovulation represent two moments of transformation from Yang to Yin and Yin to Yang, respectively. Whilst the Kidneys provide the material Yin and Yang basis for such ebb and flow, the Heart provides the impetus for

the transformation of Yang to Yin and vice versa. Moreover, Heart-Qi and Heart-Blood descend during the period to promote the downwards flow of blood and during ovulation to promote the discharge of the eggs (Fig. 12.5).

Box 12.3 summarizes the interrelationship between the Heart and the Kidneys.

LIVER AND LUNGS

There are two aspects to the relationship between Liver and Lungs:

- The relationship between Lung-Qi and Liver-Blood
- The relationship between the descending of Lung-Qi and the ascending of Liver-Qi

Box 12.3 Heart and Kidneys

- The mutual assistance of Fire and Water
 - The Heart pertains to Fire and is in the Upper Burner; the Kidneys pertain to Water and are in the Lower Burner
 - Fire and Water communicate with each and mutually assist each other
 - Heart-Yang descends to the Kidneys, Kidney-Yin ascends to the Heart
- The common root of Mind and Essence
 - The Heart houses the Mind, the Kidneys house the Essence and Will-power (*Zhi*)
 - The Essence is the basis for a stable and happy Mind; the state of the Mind influences the Essence
 - The Mind of the Heart and the Will-power of the Kidneys mutually affect each other
- The interrelationship of Heart and Kidneys in the menstrual cycle
 - The interrelationship between Heart and Kidneys is essential for a healthy menstrual cycle
 - The Kidneys are the origin of menstrual blood and are the source of the ebb and flow of Yin and Yang in the menstrual cycle
 - The Heart controls the discharge of menstrual blood at menstruation and of eggs at ovulation
 - The Heart controls the transformation of Yang to Yin with the period and of Yin to Yang with ovulation

The relationship between Lung-Qi and Liver-Blood

The relationship between Lungs and Liver reflects the relationship between Qi and Blood. The Lungs govern Qi, the Liver regulates and stores Blood, and the two rely on each other to perform their respective functions. The Liver relies on Lung-Qi to regulate Blood as Lung-Qi drives Blood in the blood vessels; on the other hand, as Blood is the mother of Qi, Liver-Blood provides the moisture and nourishment for Lung-Qi to circulate properly (Fig. 12.6, left).

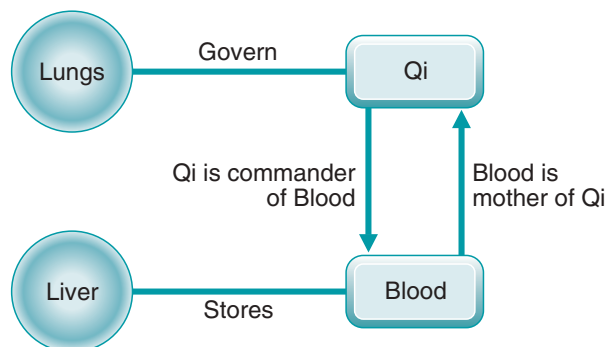


Figure 12.6 Relationship between Liver and Lungs

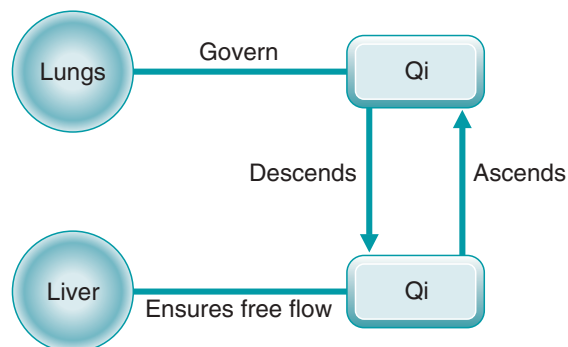
The relationship between the descending of Lung-Qi and the ascending of Liver-Qi

The relationship between Lung-Qi and Liver-Qi is based on the direction of flow of their respective Qi: Lung-Qi descends while Liver-Qi ascends (Fig 12.6, right). It is said, in fact, that 'the Liver is on the left and its Qi ascends, the Lungs are on the right and their Qi descends' ('left' and 'right' here should not be understood in a Western anatomical sense).

Although Liver-Qi flows in all directions, in this context it ascends to coordinate the movement of Qi with the Lungs. It should be noted here that this is a normal physiological ascending movement and not the pathological ascending movement of Liver-Yang rising. The Lungs rely on Liver-Qi for a smooth movement of Qi.

Therefore the descending of Lung-Qi is dependent on the ascending of Liver-Qi and vice versa. In some cases when Liver-Qi fails to ascend, this may be due to a failure of Lung-Qi to descend, and vice versa. For example, deficient Lung-Qi not descending can affect the Liver function of smooth flow of Qi, preventing Liver-Qi from rising and making it stagnate. In such cases, a person will experience listlessness (from deficiency of Qi), depression (from stagnation of Liver-Qi), cough and hypochondrial pain. This situation corresponds to 'Metal not controlling Wood' from the Five-Element point of view.

On the other hand, if Liver-Qi stagnates in the chest and fails to ascend to the Lungs, it can obstruct the flow of Lung-Qi, impairing the descending of its Qi and causing cough, breathlessness and hypochondrial distension. This situation corresponds to 'Wood insulting Metal' according to the Five Elements (see Figs 12.6 and 3.15).



Box 12.4 summarizes the interrelationship between the Liver and the Lungs.

Box 12.4 Liver and Lungs

- The relationship between Lung-Qi and Liver-Blood
 - The Lungs govern Qi; the Liver stores Blood
 - The Liver relies on Lung-Qi to regulate Blood; Lung-Qi relies on the moisture and nourishment of Liver-Blood
- The relationship between the descending of Lung-Qi and the ascending of Liver-Qi
 - Lung-Qi descends, Liver-Qi ascends
 - The descending of Lung-Qi and ascending of Liver-Qi rely on each other
 - Lung-Qi needs to descend for Liver-Qi to ascend and vice versa

LIVER AND SPLEEN

Liver and Spleen have a very close relationship, disturbances of which frequently occur in clinical practice. Under normal circumstances, Liver-Qi, with its smooth flow, helps the Spleen to transform, separate and transport. Furthermore, Liver-Qi ensures the smooth flow of bile, which also helps digestion. If Liver-Qi is normal, digestion will be good and the Spleen will be aided in the performance of its function. By ensuring the smooth flow of Qi all over the body and in all directions, the Liver ensures that Spleen-Qi flows upwards, the normal direction of Spleen-Qi (Fig. 12.7).

Stagnant Liver-Qi disrupts the Spleen's ability to transform and transport food and fluids and, in particular, the upward flow of Spleen-Qi. This manifests as abdominal distension, hypochondrial pain and loose stools. This situation corresponds to 'Wood overacting on Earth' according to the theory of the Five Elements, and is a common clinical finding.

As usual there is a reciprocal relationship, and the ascending of Spleen-Qi also aids the Liver's smooth flow of Qi. If Spleen-Qi is deficient and its transformation and transportation impaired, food will not be digested properly and will be retained in the Middle Burner, often also with the formation of Dampness. This in turn may affect the circulation of Liver-Qi and

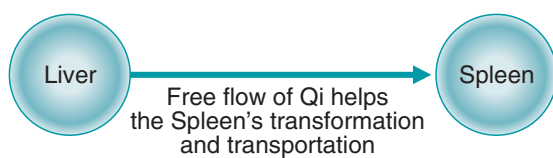


Figure 12.7 Free flow of Liver-Qi influence on Spleen

impair the smooth flow of Qi in the Middle Burner, causing abdominal distension, hypochondrial pain and irritability. This situation corresponds to 'Earth insulting Wood' according to the theory of the Five Elements (Fig. 12.8).



Clinical note

LIV-14 Qimen harmonizes Liver and Stomach; LIV-13 Zhangmen harmonizes Liver and Spleen

Box 12.5 summarizes the interrelationship between the Liver and the Spleen.

Box 12.5 Liver and Spleen

- The Liver stores Blood; the Spleen makes Blood
- The free flow of Liver-Qi helps the Spleen's function of transformation and transportation
- The ascending of Spleen-Qi helps the free flow of Liver-Qi

LIVER AND KIDNEYS

The relationship between Liver and Kidneys, of considerable clinical significance, is based on the mutual exchange between Blood and Essence. Liver-Blood nourishes and replenishes Kidney-Essence, and this in turn contributes to the making of Blood (because the Essence produces bone marrow, which makes Blood). The Kidneys also contribute to making Blood through the action of the Original Qi (ch. 3). This is why it is said that 'Liver and Kidneys have a common origin' and 'Essence and Blood have a common source'. Moreover, Kidney-Yin nourishes Liver-Yin (which includes Liver-Blood), in agreement with the Five-Element theory which states that 'Water nourishes Wood'.

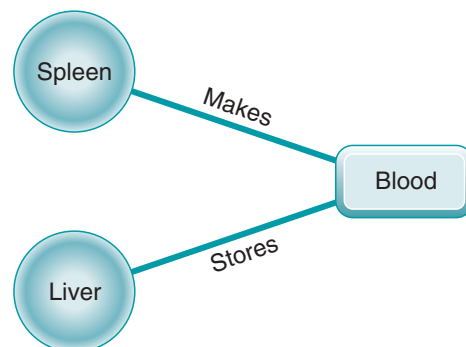


Figure 12.8 Relationship between Liver and Spleen

Deficient Kidney-Essence may lead to deficiency of Blood, with symptoms of dizziness, blurred vision and tinnitus. If Kidney-Yin is deficient it fails to nourish Liver-Yin. Deficient Liver-Yin leads to hyperactivity and rising of Liver-Yang, causing blurred vision, tinnitus, dizziness, irritability, and headaches.

Deficient Liver-Blood may cause weakness of Kidney-Essence, because this will lack the nourishment of Liver-Blood: the result will be deafness, tinnitus and nocturnal emissions (Fig. 12.9).

The relationship between Liver and Kidneys is particularly important in gynaecology. The Liver stores the Blood that supplies the Uterus with Blood, while the Kidneys are the origin of *Tian Gui*, which is the substance from which menstrual blood derives (Fig. 12.10). Therefore, these two organs are of paramount importance for the woman to have a regular and normal menstrual cycle. The Liver and Kidney channels are especially important in gynaecology because they are closely linked with the Directing and Penetrating Vessels (*Ren Mai* and *Chong Mai*).

Box 12.6 summarizes the interrelationship between the Liver and the Kidneys.

Box 12.6 Liver and Kidneys

- The Liver stores Blood and the Kidneys store Essence
- Liver-Blood replenishes the Essence
- The Essence contributes to making Blood, which is stored by the Liver
- The Original Qi of the Kidneys also contributes to making Blood
- In gynaecology, the Kidneys are the origin of *Tian Gui* and menstrual blood, while the Liver provides Blood to the Uterus
- Both Liver and Kidney channels are closely connected to the Directing and Penetrating Vessels (*Ren Mai* and *Chong Mai*)

SPLEEN AND LUNGS

The Spleen and Lungs mutually assist each other in their functions. The Spleen extracts the refined Essence of Food and sends it up to the Lungs where it combines with air to form Gathering Qi (*Zong Qi*). In this way, Spleen-Qi benefits Lung-Qi, as it provides Food-Qi from which Qi is formed. In its turn, the Spleen relies on the descending of Lung-Qi to help in the transformation and transportation of food and Body Fluids (Fig. 12.11). Thus Lung-Qi has an influence on Spleen-Qi. Hence the saying: 'The Spleen is the origin of Qi and the Lungs are the axis of Qi'.

If Spleen-Qi is deficient, then Food-Qi (*Food Qi*) will be deficient and the production of Qi, particularly that of the Lungs, will be impaired. This will result in tiredness, weak limbs, breathlessness and a weak voice. The theory of the Five Elements describes this as 'Earth not producing Metal'.

Another important consequence of Spleen deficiency is that the fluids will not be transformed and may accumulate to form Phlegm, which usually settles in the Lungs, impairing the Lung functions. Hence the

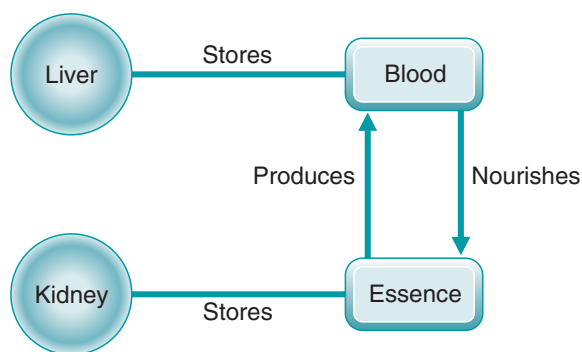


Figure 12.9 Relationship between Liver and Kidneys

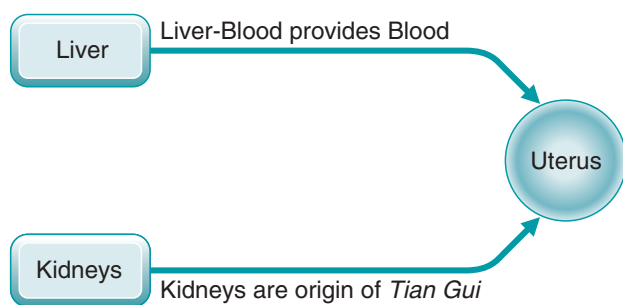


Figure 12.10 Relationship between Liver and Kidneys with regard to menstruation

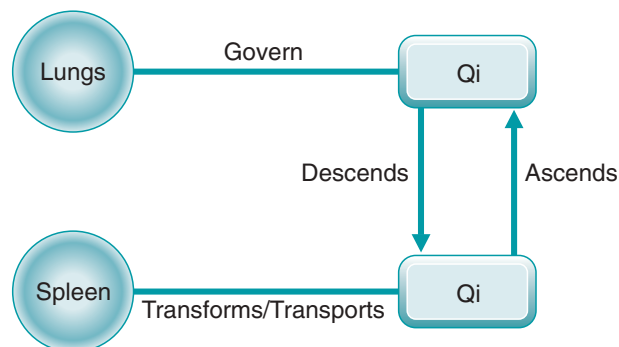


Figure 12.11 Relationship between Spleen and Lungs

saying ‘The Spleen is the origin of Phlegm and the Lungs store it’.

If Lung-Qi is weak and its descending impaired, the Spleen cannot transform and transport the fluids, causing oedema.

Box 12.7 summarizes the interrelationship between the Spleen and the Lungs.

Box 12.7 Spleen and Lungs

- The Spleen makes Qi; the Lungs govern Qi
- Spleen-Qi ascends, Lung-Qi descends
- Spleen-Qi transports Food-Qi to the Lungs; hence the Lungs are dependent on ascending of Spleen-Qi
- The descending of Lung-Qi helps the Spleen's transformation and transportation of food essence
- Deficiency of Spleen-Qi may lead to Phlegm, which affects the Lungs

SPLEEN AND KIDNEYS

The relationship between Spleen and Kidneys is one of mutual nourishment. The Spleen is the Root of Post-Heaven Qi, while the Kidneys are the Root of Pre-Heaven Qi (Fig. 12.12). As mentioned before, the Post-Heaven and Pre-Heaven Qi mutually support one another. The Post-Heaven Qi continually replenishes the Pre-Heaven Qi with the Qi produced from food, and the Pre-Heaven Qi assists in the production of Qi by providing the heat necessary for digestion and transformation (through the Fire of the Gate of Life).

If Spleen-Qi is deficient, not enough Qi will be produced to replenish Kidney-Essence; this may cause tiredness, lack of appetite, tinnitus, dizziness and lower backache.

If Kidney-Yang is deficient, the Fire of the Gate of Life cannot warm the Spleen in its activity of transformation and transportation, causing diarrhoea and

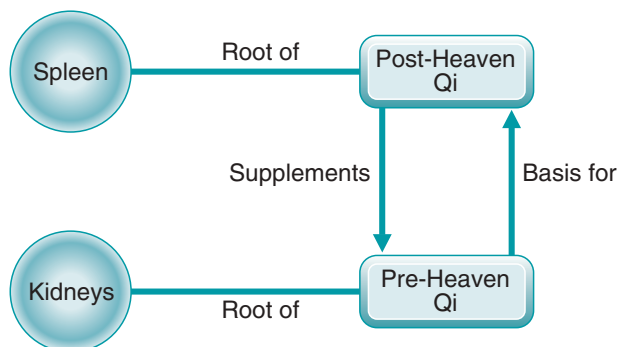


Figure 12.12 Relationship between Spleen and Kidneys

chilliness. This is termed by the Five-Element theory ‘Fire not producing Earth’.

The Spleen and Kidney also assist each other in the transformation and transportation of Body Fluids: Kidney-Yang provides the heat necessary to the Spleen in order to transform and transport fluids. Spleen-Qi helps the Kidneys in transforming and excreting fluids. If Spleen-Qi cannot transform and transport the fluids, these may accumulate to form Dampness, which can impair the Kidney function of governing Water, further aggravating the Dampness. On the other hand, if Kidney-Yang is deficient, the Fire of the Gate of Life cannot provide the heat necessary for the Spleen to transform the fluids and this can cause Dampness or oedema, diarrhoea and chilliness.

Box 12.8 summarizes the interrelationship between the Spleen and the Kidneys.

Box 12.8 Spleen and Kidneys

- The Spleen is the Root of Post-Heaven Qi, the Kidneys are the Root of Pre-Heaven Qi
- Kidney-Yang provides the heat to the Spleen necessary to transport and transform food essence
- Spleen-Qi helps the Kidneys' transformation and excretion of fluids

LUNGS AND KIDNEYS

The Lungs and Kidneys are related in many ways. First of all, the Lungs send Qi and fluids down to the Kidneys, and the Kidneys respond by holding the Qi down and evaporating some of the fluids and sending the resulting vapour back up to the Lungs to keep them moist. The relationship between Lungs and Kidneys can therefore be analysed in terms of Qi or fluids:

- The relationship between Lungs and Kidneys with regard to Qi
- The relationship between Lungs and Kidneys with regard to fluids

The relationship between Lungs and Kidneys with regard to Qi

In terms of Qi, the Lungs govern Qi and respiration and send Qi down to the Kidneys. The Kidneys respond by holding Qi down. Thus, Lungs and Kidneys must communicate with and respond to each other to achieve

proper breathing. This relationship is also mirrored in the relationship between Gathering Qi in the chest (which pertains to the Lungs) and Original Qi in the lower abdomen (which belongs to the Kidneys). Gathering Qi has to flow down to obtain nourishment from the Original Qi, while this has to flow up to the chest to assist in the production of Qi and Blood. Thus, the Lungs' function of governing Qi and respiration is dependent on the Kidneys' function of reception of Qi and vice versa.

If the Kidneys are weak and their function of reception of Qi is impaired, the Kidneys will fail to hold Qi down and Qi will flow back up to the chest, obstructing the Lungs' descending function and causing breathlessness (more on inhalation), cough and asthma.



Clinical note

The points to stimulate the descending of Lung-Qi to the Kidneys and the Kidneys' grasping of Qi are LU-7 Lieque, Ren-4 Guanyuan and KI-13 Qixue

The relationship between Lungs and Kidneys with regard to fluids

In terms of fluids, the Lungs control the Water passages and send fluids down to the Kidneys; the Kidneys respond by evaporating some of the fluids and sending them back up to the Lungs to keep them moist (Fig. 12.13). This is why it is said in Chinese medicine that the 'Kidneys govern Water and the Lungs are the Upper Source of Water'.

If Lung-Qi is deficient, it cannot send fluids downwards and the Lungs cannot communicate with the Kidneys and Bladder, causing incontinence or retention of urine. If Kidney-Yang is deficient and cannot

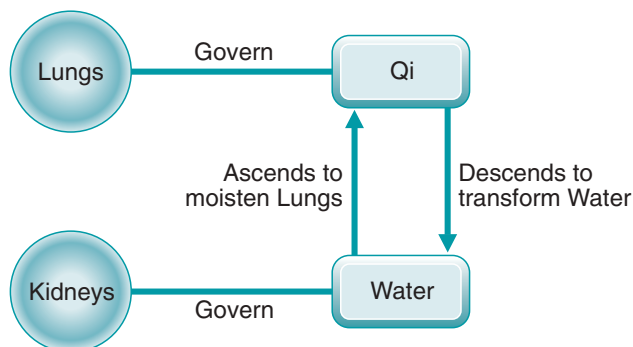


Figure 12.13 Relationship between Lungs and Kidneys

transform and excrete the fluids in the Lower Burner, they may accumulate to cause oedema, which will impair the descending and diffusing of Lung-Qi. Deficiency of Kidney-Yin results in deficiency of fluids in the Lower Burner. The consequence of this is that fluids fail to rise to keep the Lungs moist, thus causing deficiency of Lung-Yin. The symptoms of this are a dry throat at night, a dry cough, night sweating and a feeling of heat in the palms and soles of feet.

Box 12.9 summarizes the interrelationship between the Lungs and the Kidneys.

Box 12.9 Lungs and Kidneys

- Relationship between Lungs and Kidneys with regard to Qi
 - The Lungs send Qi down to the Kidneys, which 'hold' it: this makes breathing normal
 - Gathering Qi of the chest (related to the Lungs) communicates with Original Qi in the abdomen (related to the Kidneys)
- Relationship between Lungs and Kidneys with regard to fluids
 - Lung-Qi sends fluids down to the Kidneys
 - Kidney-Yang evaporates some and sends resulting 'vapour' back up to the Lungs to moisten them

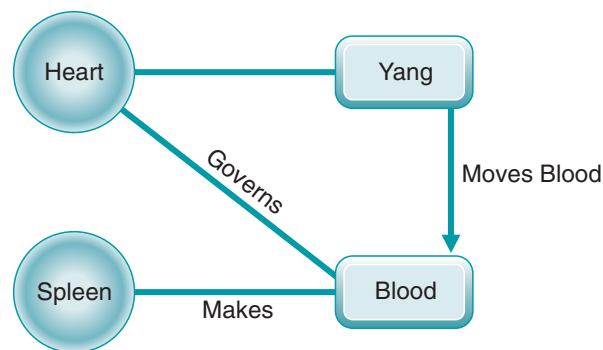


Figure 12.14 Relationship between Spleen and Heart

SPLEEN AND HEART

Spleen and Heart are interrelated because of their connection with Blood. The Spleen makes Blood (because it provides the Essence of Food, which is the basis for Blood) and it is therefore of paramount importance to the Heart, which governs Blood (Fig. 12.14). If Spleen-Qi is deficient and cannot make enough Blood, this will often lead to deficiency of Heart-Blood, with symptoms of dizziness, poor memory, insomnia and palpitations.

Box 12.10 Spleen and Heart

- The Spleen makes Blood; the Heart governs Blood
- Spleen-Qi transports Food-Qi to the Heart where it is transformed into Blood
- Heart-Blood nourishes the Spleen
- The descending of Heart-Qi helps the Spleen's transformation and transportation of food essences

On the other hand, Heart-Yang pushes Blood in the vessels and Heart-Blood nourishes the Spleen. If Heart-Yang is deficient it will fail to push the Blood in the vessels and the Spleen will suffer as it makes and controls Blood.

Box 12.10 summarizes the interrelationship between the Spleen and the Heart.



Learning outcomes

In this section you will have learned:

- Heart and Lungs
 - Heart governs Blood, Lungs govern Qi
 - Qi is the commander of Blood, Blood is the mother of Qi
 - If Qi circulates well, Blood circulates; if Qi is stagnant, Blood stagnates
 - Qi provides warmth to Blood; Blood provides a liquid vehicle for Qi
 - Gathering Qi of the chest is influenced by both Lungs and Heart
 - Food Qi of the Spleen goes to the Heart to make Blood via the agency of the Lungs
- Heart and Liver
 - Heart governs Blood, Liver stores Blood
 - Liver-Blood deficiency often leads to Heart-Blood deficiency
 - The Heart houses the Mind, the Liver houses the Ethereal Soul
 - The Heart (through the Mind) recognizes, controls and integrates emotions; the Liver ensures the smooth flow of emotions
 - The Ethereal Soul (of the Liver) is the 'coming and going' of the Mind (of the Heart)
- Heart and Kidneys
 - The relationship between Fire and Water
 - The interrelationship of the Heart and Kidneys in the menstrual cycle
 - The common root of Mind and Essence
- Liver and Lungs
 - The relationship between Lung-Qi and Liver-Blood
 - The Lungs govern Qi, the Liver stores Blood
 - The Liver relies on Lung-Qi to regulate blood: Lung-Qi relies on the moisture and nourishment of Liver-Blood
 - The relationship between the descending of Lung-Qi and the ascending of Liver-Qi
 - Lung-Qi descends, Liver-Qi ascends
- The descending of Lung-Qi and Liver-Qi rely on each other: Lung-Qi needs to descend for Liver-Qi to ascend and vice versa
- Liver and Spleen
 - The Liver stores Blood, the Spleen makes Blood
 - The free flow of Liver-Qi helps the Spleen's function of transformation and transportation
 - The ascending of Spleen-Qi helps the free flow of Liver-Qi
- Liver and Kidneys
 - The Liver stores Blood and the Kidneys store Essence
 - Liver-Blood replenishes the Essence
 - The Essence contributes to making Blood, which is stored by the Liver
 - The Original Qi of the Kidneys also contributes to making Blood
 - In gynaecology, the Kidneys are the origin of *Tian Gui* and menstrual blood, while the Liver provides Blood to the Uterus
 - Both Liver and Kidney channels are closely connected to the Directing and Penetrating Vessels (*Ren Mai* and *Chong Mai*)
- Spleen and Lungs
 - The Spleen makes Qi, the Lungs govern Qi
 - Spleen-Qi ascends, Lung-Qi descends
 - Spleen-Qi transports Food-Qi to the Lungs: therefore function of the Lungs is dependent on ascending of Spleen-Qi
 - The descending of Lung-Qi helps the Spleen's transformation and transportation of food essence
 - Deficiency of Spleen-Qi may lead to the formation of Phlegm, which affects the Lungs
- Spleen and Kidneys
 - The Spleen is the root of Post-Heaven Qi; the Kidneys are the root of Pre-Heaven Qi
 - Kidney-Yang provides the heat to the Spleen necessary to transport and transform food essence
 - Spleen-Qi helps the Kidneys' function of the transformation and excretion of fluids
- Lungs and Kidneys
 - Relationship between the Lungs and Kidneys with regard to Qi
 - The Lungs send Qi down to the Kidneys, which 'hold' it: this makes breathing normal
 - Gathering Qi of the chest (related to the Lungs) communicates with Original Qi in the abdomen (related to the Kidneys)
 - Relationship between the Lungs and Kidneys with regard to fluids
 - Lung-Qi sends fluids down to the Kidneys
 - Kidney-Yang evaporates some and sends the resulting 'vapour' back up to the Lungs to moisten them
- Spleen and Heart
 - The Spleen makes Blood, the Heart governs Blood
 - Spleen-Qi transports Food-Qi to the heart where it is transformed into Blood
 - Heart-Blood nourishes the Spleen
 - The descending of Heart-Qi helps the Spleen's transformation and transportation of food essences

Self-assessment questions

Heart and Lungs

1. Which two vital substances do the Heart and Lungs govern? How does this affect the relationship between the two organs?
2. Explain the relationship between Qi and Blood.
3. If Lung-Qi is deficient, what can happen to Heart-Qi?
4. How can the pattern of Excessive Heart Fire affect the Lungs?
5. Why is it common for both Heart- and Lung-Qi to be deficient at the same time?
6. How does Gathering Qi affect the function of the Heart and Lungs?
7. What emotion depletes both Heart- and Lung-Qi?

Heart and Liver

1. Explain the relationship between the Heart and Liver in terms of their action upon Blood.
2. What effect can Liver-Blood deficiency have on the Heart?
3. How may deficient Heart-Blood affect the Liver? What symptoms might this situation give rise to?
4. Which psychological aspects of the person can the Liver and Heart be said to 'house'?
5. Explain how both the Heart and the Liver have an effect upon the emotions and psychological state.

Heart and Kidneys

1. In terms of the theory of the Five Elements, which elements do the Heart and Kidneys correspond to? Explain the relationship of these two elements:
 - i. from a Five-Element perspective
 - ii. from an organ perspective.
2. Which Heart pattern can develop if Kidney-Yang is deficient?
3. Which Heart pattern can develop if Kidney-Yin is deficient?
4. Explain how the Mind and Essence have a common root.
5. What can happen to the Mind if a person's Essence is weak?
6. What can happen to the Essence if a person's Mind is disturbed by emotional problems? How might this manifest?
7. What is the spiritual aspect of the Kidney organ?
8. Explain how the relationship between the Mind and Essence reflects the relationship between the Mind and the Will-power. (For example, how will the Will-power be affected if the Essence is weak, and vice versa?)
9. Describe what happens to Kidney-Yin and Kidney-Yang during the menstrual cycle.
10. In which two ways does the Heart play a role in the menstrual cycle?

Liver and Lungs

1. The relationship between the Liver and Lungs reflects the relationship between which two vital substances? Explain.
2. How does the Liver rely on Lung-Qi to regulate Blood?

3. How does Liver-Blood affect Lung-Qi?
4. What is the direction of the flow of Lung-Qi and Liver-Qi?
5. Explain how deficient Lung-Qi will affect the Liver function of the smooth flow of Qi. What situation does this correspond to in Five-Element terms?

Liver and Spleen

1. In what two ways does the Liver help the Spleen to transform, separate and transport food and fluids?
2. What is the normal direction of Spleen-Qi?
3. What symptoms can occur if stagnant Liver-Qi disrupts the Spleen's ability to transform food and fluids? What situation does this correspond to in Five-Element terms?
4. How can deficient Spleen-Qi affect Liver-Qi? Which symptoms can this cause? Which Five-Element pattern does this situation correspond to?
5. Explain how both the Liver and Spleen have a relationship with Blood.

Liver and Kidneys

1. Explain how the relationship between the Liver and Kidneys is based on the mutual exchange between Blood and Essence.
2. What is the relationship between Kidney-Yin and Liver-Yin and Blood? Describe this relationship in Five-Element terms.
3. If Liver-Blood is deficient, what can happen to Kidney-Essence? What symptoms can occur in this situation?
4. If Kidney-Yin is deficient, what can happen to Liver-Yin and Liver-Blood? What symptoms can occur in this situation?
5. Explain how both the Liver and Kidneys play a role in ensuring a regular menstrual cycle.
6. Which extraordinary channels are the Liver and Kidney channels closely linked to?

Spleen and Lungs

1. Explain the role played by the Spleen and Lungs in the formation of Gathering Qi.
2. What is the direction of Lung-Qi? How does this direction of Lung-Qi aid the action of Spleen-Qi?
3. If Spleen-Qi is deficient, how can Lung-Qi be affected? In this situation, what symptoms may occur? In Five-Element terms, how is this situation described?
4. Describe the relationship the Spleen and Lungs have with Phlegm.

Spleen and Kidneys

1. The Spleen is the root of Post-Heaven Qi while the Kidneys are the root of Pre-Heaven Qi. How do Post- and Pre-Heaven Qi mutually support each other?
2. How can a deficiency of Spleen-Qi affect Kidney-Essence? What symptoms may occur in this situation?
3. What can happen to Spleen-Qi if Kidney-Yang is deficient? In this situation, what symptoms may occur? In Five-Element terms, how is this situation described?
4. Describe the role played by the Spleen and Kidneys with regards to Body Fluids.

Lungs and Kidneys

1. Explain how the Lungs and Kidneys are related in terms of Qi and fluids.
2. Explain the relationship of Gathering Qi and Original Qi.
3. What happens to the Kidney organ if Lung-Qi is deficient? What symptoms may occur?
4. How will Kidney-Yang deficiency affect the Lungs? What symptoms may occur?
5. How will a deficiency of Kidney-Yin affect the Lungs? What symptoms may occur?

Spleen and Heart

1. Explain the role the Spleen and Heart play with regards to Blood.
2. If Spleen-Qi is deficient and cannot make enough blood, what can happen to the Heart?

See [p. 1258](#) for answers

END NOTES

1. Beijing College of Traditional Chinese Medicine 1980 Practical Chinese Medicine (*Shi Yong Zhong Yi Xue 实用中医学*), Beijing Publishing House, Beijing, p. 51.
2. Although the role of the Kidneys and Heart in regulating the menstrual cycle is recognized in traditional Chinese medicine, the more specific aspects of the influence of the Heart on the discharge of menstrual blood and eggs is modern. This account is based on personal communications from Dr Xia Gui Cheng, former director of the Gynaecology Department of the Affiliated Hospital for Traditional Chinese Medicine in Nanjing.